permanent imprint on Deccani art. Art historians have marvelled at ‘his transformation from a competent but conventional painter into a master of great imagination and unique style during his Bijapur years’, a transformation all the more remarkable as the painter was now over fifty years of age. Farrukh Beg would only return to the Mughal court in 1609, bringing with him a denser colour palette and a certain fascination for outsized tropical flowers.

Also of consequence to the Mughal court was the introduction of tobacco by Asad Beg who had discovered it in the Deccan. He brought back with him a handsome pipe whose stem was studded with jewels and enamel at both ends. The mouthpiece was made of crimson carnelian and the burner was made of gold. Asad Beg also had a fine betel bag which Ibrahim Adil Shah II had given him and this he filled with tobacco and arranged everything pleasingly on a silver tray to present to the emperor. Akbar’s curiosity was piqued, and he asked to try some. When he had begun smoking the tobacco his physician rushed to his side and, taking the pipe away from him, asked Mirza Aziz Koka to try it first. ‘This is an untried medicine,’ grumbled the physician, ‘about which the doctors have written nothing. How can we describe to Your Majesty the qualities of such unknown things?’ But Asad Beg chided the physician saying, not unreasonably, that ‘every custom in the world has been new at one time or another’. Akbar was pleased with his reasoning and told Aziz Koka, ‘Truly, we must not reject a thing that has been adopted by the wise men of other nations merely because we cannot find it in our books, or how shall we progress?’ After trying tobacco once, however, Akbar did not adopt the practice, though all the noblemen of the court were soon smoking it appreciatively.

At his rebel court at Allahabad, Salim continued to torment the Jesuits at Akbar’s court with signs of great favour. He had spoken in private with the priests earlier, in such intimate terms as to ‘justify the hope that God would one day work in him a great miracle’. He sent a servant from Allahabad carrying carpets and other gifts for the priests and requested them to leave his father’s court for his own. He wrote letters to them in his own hand, signed with a cross, and told an Italian visitor to his court that ‘I have a very great affection for the Lord Jesus’; saying these words, Salim showed the Italian a cross of gold suspended from his neck. He sent the priests further gifts—an image of Jesus in silver and a reliquary attached to